

BENJAMIN D. PYLE



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Last updated: March 17, 2026

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Boston University School of Law

Associate Professor of Law

Boston, MA

July 2023 — Current

- Subjects Taught: Criminal Law; Employment Law
- Center for Innovation in Social Science Faculty Fellow

PUBLISHED AND FORTHCOMING WORK

Articles & Comments

- *Negligent Hiring: Recidivism and Employment with a Criminal Record*, 120 Nw. U. L. Rev. 1175 (2026).
- *Measuring Lawyer Mental Illness: Evidence from Two National Surveys*, 23 J. Empirical Legal Stud. 60 (2026). (with Clifford Rosky)
- *Informed Applicants: Anti-Discrimination Enforcement Based on the Use of Criminal Records*. 47 Berkeley J. Emp. & Lab. L. 1 (2026)
- *Invited Response: Knowledge Generation and Uncertainty in an Unpredictable Social World*, 103 B. U. L. REV. 2049 (2023).
- *Understanding Violent Crime Recidivism*, 95 NOTRE DAME L. REV. 1643 (2020). (with J.J. Prescott & Sonja Starr)
- *Identifying the Impact of Labor Market Opportunities on Criminal Behavior*, 59 INT'L REV. L. & ECON. 65 (2019). (with J.J. Prescott)

Reports

- *Second Chances Part I - Federal Employment for Workers with Past Arrests or Convictions (EEOC Federal Sector Report 2023)* (with Romella El Kharzazi and EEOC staff)

Economic Letters

- Benjamin Pyle & John C. Williams, *Data Dependence Awakens*, FRBSF ECON. LETTER 2016-12 (2016).
- Mary C. Daly, Bart Hobijn, & Benjamin Pyle, *What's Up with Wage Growth?*, FRBSF ECON. LETTER 2016-07 (2016).
- Glenn D. Rudebusch, Daniel J. Wilson, & Benjamin Pyle, *Residual Seasonality and Monetary Policy*, FRBSF ECON. LETTER 2015-27 (2015).
- Mary C. Daly, Fernanda Nechio, & Benjamin Pyle, *Finding Normal: Natural Rates and Policy Prescriptions*, FRBSF ECON. LETTER 2015-22 (2015).

WORKING PAPERS

- [A Second Look: Local Labor Markets and The Impact of Ban the Box Policies After Criminal Legal Involvement](#) (Revisions requested at the Journal of Law and Economics)

This paper estimates the impact of labor demand on the employment and recidivism outcomes of released prisoners. Higher labor demand at release generates higher earnings and lower recidivism. Reduced recidivism persists after controlling for the observed labor market outcomes of the returning cohort, suggesting that labor demand impacts crime through channels beyond the direct formal employment of returning prisoners. Difference-in-Differences based evidence suggests Ban the Box (BTB) policies delaying when employers can ask about criminal records improve labor market outcomes and lower recidivism for misdemeanor defendants. Evidence for felony defendants and returning prisoners is mixed but suggestive of similar patterns.

- [Agency Incentives and Disparate Revenue Collection: Evidence from Chicago Parking Tickets](#) (with Elizabeth Luh and James Reeves, Revisions requested at the Journal of Public Economics)

We examine enforcement patterns in administering parking tickets for failure to purchase vehicle registration, colloquially known as the sticker fine, across ticketing agencies in Chicago. Leveraging a sharp 2012 sticker fine increase in an event-study framework, we find that Chicago police increased their enforcement of sticker non-compliance across Black relative to non-Black neighborhoods, but find no disparate response in the ticketing behavior of other parking enforcement agents. This significant disparity in ticketing by police officers is not driven by changes in compliance or differences in neighborhood characteristics, but rather differential enforcement. We present suggestive evidence of differences in officer incentives and marginal parking enforcement costs as key mechanisms. An officer-specific decomposition provides evidence that disparate enforcement is not concentrated among a small handful of officers, but is instead a broader departmental phenomenon. We link this disparate enforcement to a widening of the financial instability gap across neighborhoods, including increased rates of ticket non-payment and bankruptcy filings.

- [Estimating the Impact of the Age of Criminal Majority: Decomposing Multiple Treatments in a Regression Discontinuity Framework](#) (with Michael Mueller-Smith and Caroline Walker)

This paper studies the impact of adult prosecution on recidivism and employment trajectories for first-time felony youth criminal defendants. We use extensive linked Criminal Justice Administrative Record System (CJARS) and socio-economic data from Wayne County, Michigan (Detroit). Using the discrete age of majority rule, and a regression discontinuity design, we find that adult prosecution reduces future criminal charges over 5 years by 0.48 felony cases (↓ 20%) while also worsening labor market outcomes: .76 fewer employers (↓ 19%) and \$613 less earnings (↓ 21%) per year. We develop a novel econometric framework that combines standard regression discontinuity methods with predictive machine learning models to identify mechanism-specific treatment effects that underpin the overall impact of adult prosecution. We leverage these estimates to consider four policy counterfactuals: (1) raising the age of majority, (2) increasing adult dismissals to match the juvenile disposition rates, (3) eliminating adult incarceration, and (4) expanding juvenile record sealing opportunities to those prosecuted in the adult system. All four scenarios generate positive returns for government budgets. After accounting for increases in recidivism generated by many of these policies and the corresponding victim costs borne by society, we find positive social returns for expanding the reach of juvenile record sealing and increasingly dismissing marginal adult charges, while raising the age of majority breaks even. Eliminating prison for first time adult felony defendants increases net social costs. Any opinions and conclusions expressed herein are those of the authors and do not reflect the views of the U.S. Census Bureau. The U.S. Census Bureau reviewed this data product for unauthorized disclosure of confidential information and approved the disclosure avoidance practices applied to this release (Approval number: #CBDRB-FY22-291).

- [Who Benefits from Corporate Tax Cuts? Evidence from Banks and Credit Unions around the TCJA.](#) (with Edward Fox)

The TCJA of 2017 made large changes to the taxation of corporate and pass-through businesses in the U.S. Understanding the effects of these changes is complicated by the difficulty of finding control firms whose taxation was not altered by the Act. We study the effect of the TCJA on small and medium size banks using credit unions—which compete with these banks for deposits and in making loans—as a novel control group. Credit unions were not taxed both before and after the Act. Using a difference-in-difference framework, we find that an important fraction of the incidence of the tax cut goes to depositors. We find little evidence that employees or borrowers from banks receive a share of the tax cut in the form of higher wages or lower interest rates on loans or that banks increase their investment in fixed assets as a result of the Act.

- [Women in Law and the Draft](#) (with Thomas Helgerman)

During the Vietnam War, women's representation in full-time law school programs grew by a factor of 5 from 3.7% of all students in 1964 to 20.1% of all students in 1973. This paper considers the hypothesis that part of this increase was precipitated by a change in the draft status of men in law school. In 1968, men studying law would lose their ability to claim a 2-S deferment, and the threat of tuition loss to law schools resulting from the draft risk of enrolled men prompted law schools to increase the fraction of their incoming class that were women. To test this hypothesis, we construct a school-by-year dataset of enrollment counts split by sex and full-time/part-time status. Using a uniform adoption difference-in-differences design, we find that women's representation rises by 2% in full-time programs relative to part-time programs, which are far less exposed to draft risk, representing a large 44% increase over women's baseline representation of 4.5% in 1967.

EDUCATION

University of Michigan

J.D., Magna Cum Laude

August 2018 – May 2021

Journal: Articles Editor for Michigan Journal of Law Reform

Clinic: Workers' Rights/Unemployment Insurance Clinic (2 years)

Awards: Order of the Coif; Book Award for Legal Ethics

University of Chicago's Donald M. Ephraim Paper Prize in Law and Economics

Ph.D. in Economics

August 2016 – 2023

Master's of Arts in Economics

January 2018

Fields Completed: Labor, Public Finance

Awards: 2016 - 2017 William Haber Graduate Fellow; 2023 John E. Parker Memorial Prize
in Labor Economics and Human Resources

Claremont McKenna College

B.A. Philosophy, Politics, and Economics; Mathematics, Magna Cum Laude

May 2013

Awards: Edward J. Sexton PPE Fellow, Robert Day Scholar,
Dean's List, National Merit Scholar, Rotary Scholarship

AWARDS, GRANTS, AND PROFESSIONAL ENGAGEMENT

- Faculty Small Grant Program (FSGP), University of Utah (\$10,000) (“Revisiting and Reconciling Estimates of Lawyer Mental Health”) (2025) (Co-PI: Clifford Rosky)
- Grant-in-Aid, University of Minnesota (\$56,187) (2025) (“The Evolution of Legal Labor Markets Women’s Entry to the Legal Profession, Anti-Discrimination Enforcement, and Labor Market Impacts of Government Subsidies for Legal Services”) (Co-PI: Thomas Helgerman)
- CISS Faculty Pilot Grant (\$5,000) (2025) (“Title VII Enforcement, Education, and Women’s Representation in Law”) (Co-PI: Thomas Helgerman)
- Vital Projects at Proteus (\$20,000) (2019) (“Understanding Recidivism Rates for Homicide Offenders”) (Co-PI: J.J. Prescott)
- Presentations & Papers in Conferences: University of Texas at Austin Law and Economics Workshop* (2026); Conference on Empirical Legal Studies* (2025); The 20th Annual Colloquium on Scholarship in Employment and Labor Law* (COSELL) (2025); American Law and Economics Annual Conference* (2025), Boston University Law and Economics Seminar* (2025); Junior Scholars Conference* (2025); Vanderbilt Law and Economics Seminar* (2025); AALS Annual Meeting* (2025); The 19th Annual Colloquium on Scholarship in Employment and Labor Law* (COSELL) (2024); Conference on Empirical Legal Studies* (Emory, 2024); Regulating Labor Across the Atlantic (Michigan, 2024); AALS Employment Discrimination Working Group* (2024); Western Economic Association International Conference* (2024); Virtual Crime Economics (ViCE) Seminar* (2024); Texas Economics of Crime Workshop (TxECW)* (2024); Harvard Law, Economics, & Organization Seminar* (2024); NBER’s Crime Spring Meeting* (2024); Association of American Law Schools Annual Meeting, Empirical Legal Studies* (2024); Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management* (2023); University of Texas at Austin Law and Economics Workshop* (2023); NBER Summer Institute, Crime Session (2023); American Law and Economics Annual Conference* (2023), Midwest Economics Association* (2023); NBER’s Program for Children Meeting (2023); Conference on Empirical Legal Studies* (UVA, 2022); 2022 Interactions: Bringing Together Econometrics and Applied Microeconomics (University of Wisconsin Madison, 2022); Program on Empirical Legal Studies* (Claremont McKenna College, 2018) (Star indicates presenter)
- Executive Committee Member - AALS Empirical Study of Legal Education and the Legal Profession Section (2025-), Review Committee for APPAM 2025 Crime & Justice
- Referee: Yale Law Journal; Journal of Public Economics; American Law and Economics Review; International Review of Law and Economics; Review of Law and Economics; Law and Society Review; Białostockie Studia Prawnicze; Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy
- Bar membership: California
- Faculty EEO Hearing Panelist

PREVIOUS TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Michigan
Graduate Student Instructor

Ann Arbor, MI
August 2017 — May 2021

- Crime & Public Policy (Upper Level Writing Course); Fall & Winter 2018, Fall 2019, Winter 2021
- Ethics & Economics (Upper Level Writing Course); Fall 2020
- Principles of Economics II; Winter 2019
- Economics of Education (Upper Level Writing Course); Fall 2017, Summer 2018

- Introduction to Economics with Eric Helland

PREVIOUS RESEARCH AND LEGAL EXPERIENCE

Washtenaw Prosecutor's Office and ACLU Michigan

Special Assistant to the Prosecutor

Ann Arbor, MI

March 2022 — June 2023

University of Michigan

Graduate Research Assistant

Ann Arbor, MI

May 2019 — July 2023

Freelance

Litigation Consultant

Ann Arbor, MI

2017 — 2023

Equal Employment Opportunity Commission

Graduate Research Fellowship

Ann Arbor, MI

June 2021 — December 2021

National Employment Law Project

Researcher

Ann Arbor, MI

June 2021 — August 2021

Older employment

pre-2017

- Research Associate at the Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco (2013-2016); Research Assistant at the Claremont McKenna's Financial Economics Institute (2011-13); Summer Analyst at Deutsche Bank (2012); Research Assistant at the White House Council of Economic Advisers (2011); Research Assistant at RAND Corporation Institute for Civil Justice (2010-2011)

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- Skilled in Microsoft Office Suite, VBA, STATA, Matlab, CUDA, Bloomberg, Lexis, Westlaw, Haver, and LaTeX.
- Some experience in R, Java, Python, Eviews, Gauss, and Mathematica.